

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Elon Musk's xAI** is working with Valor Equity Partners to raise as much as \$12 billion to equip a new data center to help train and power the company's Grok chatbot. **A1**
- ◆ **U.S. stocks ended mixed**, with the S&P 500 rising 0.1% to a record, the Dow gaining 0.4% and the Nasdaq retreating 0.4% from a record set Monday. **B11**
- ◆ **GM reported** net income shrank 35% in the second quarter as automotive duties weighed on results and warned the impact will be greater in the next three months. **B1**
- ◆ **Coca-Cola said** it would introduce a new Coke product sweetened with cane sugar while continuing to rely on high-fructose corn syrup for other drinks. **B1**
- ◆ **Sanofi said** it would acquire biotech company Vocabio for as much as \$1.6 billion, seeking to strengthen its portfolio of respiratory vaccines. **B4**
- ◆ **Halliburton expects** markets will be softer than previously thought after the oil-field-services company logged lower second-quarter profit and revenue. **B3**
- ◆ **Home builder** D.R. Horton lowered the high end of its revenue outlook after its third-quarter results declined from a year earlier. **B2**
- ◆ **PulteGroup's results** weakened in its latest quarter as fewer homes were purchased amid low consumer confidence and economic challenges. **B2**
- ◆ **The European Commission** opened an in-depth investigation into Universal Music's \$775 million takeover of label Downtown Music, citing competition concerns. **B1**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The U.S. and Japan** have struck a trade agreement, Trump said in a social-media post, saying he would set his so-called reciprocal tariffs at 15% for the country. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump said the U.S.** and the Philippines reached a trade pact and the administration announced details on its trade framework with Indonesia. **A2**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** is using its global trade wars to advance the interests of the U.S. technology industry, seeking to prevent foreign countries from targeting American internet firms. **A1**
- ◆ **House Speaker** Mike Johnson cut short this week's legislative session and sent members home early for their summer break to avoid a vote on Epstein investigation files. **A1**
- ◆ **Attorney General** Pam Bondi fired judges' pick for New Jersey's new top federal prosecutor, escalating a clash between the Trump administration and the judiciary. **A3**
- ◆ **China blocked** a U.S. government employee from leaving the country after the person traveled there in a personal capacity, the U.S. Embassy in Beijing said. **A5**
- ◆ **Protests erupted** in Kyiv after the government moved to gut Ukraine's anticorruption agency, which opponents see as a step to consolidate power around Zelensky. **A7**
- ◆ **Britain will** stick to its budget rules despite challenges that include upheavals in geopolitics and trade, Chancellor of the Exchequer Rachel Reeves said. **A16**
- ◆ **Died: Ozzy Osbourne**, 76, heavy metal pioneer. **A3**

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A Nice Day for a Wet Wedding in the Philippines



ARON FAVILA/ASSOCIATED PRESS

S.W.A.K.: Bride Jamaica Aguilar and groom Jade Rick Verdillo slogged down the aisle of Barasoain Church in Malolos, Philippines, on Tuesday, braving flooding caused by monsoon rains intensified by Typhoon Whipa. Their reasoning: All marriages face challenges.

U.S., Japan Reach Trade Deal; Reciprocal Levies Set at 15%

By GAVIN BADE AND MEGUMI FUJIKAWA

The U.S. and Japan have struck a trade agreement, President Trump said in a social-media post Tuesday evening, saying he would set his reciprocal tariffs at 15% for the country.

Under the deal, Japan will invest \$550 billion in the U.S., Trump said in his post on Truth Social, writing the U.S. would receive “90% of the Profits” from the investments, without providing further de-

tails. Japan will also “open their Country to Trade including Cars and Trucks, Rice and certain other Agricultural Products,” Trump posted.

Critically for Japan and its powerhouse auto industry, Tokyo’s top trade negotiator said tariffs on autos will also be lowered to 15% from their current 25%.

Trump said at a meeting with Republican lawmakers at the White House that the Japan deal is the “largest trade deal in history—maybe the largest deal in history.”

He added that the Japanese government would enter a “joint venture” for liquefied natural gas exportation in Alaska.

The administration and gas industry have long sought to secure partners for a proposed export project in that state.

Japanese Prime Minister Shigeru Ishiba said he received a report on the deal from his chief negotiator.

“The government was determined to protect national interests,” Ishiba told report-

ers Wednesday morning in Tokyo.

The deal “will lead to Japan and the U.S. working together to create jobs, produce high-quality goods, and contribute to fulfilling various roles in the world going forward,” he added.

Tokyo’s chief negotiator, Ryosei Akazawa, wrote “mission accomplished” on his personal X account, sharing a *Please turn to page A2*

◆ **Global economy powers through trade chaos..... A2**

Tariff Threats Aim To Boost Big Tech

By AMRITH RAMKUMAR AND GAVIN BADE

WASHINGTON—The Trump administration is using its global trade wars to advance the interests of the U.S. technology industry, seeking to prevent foreign countries from targeting U.S. internet firms.

The administration hopes to use the threat of tariffs and access to the U.S. economy to stop multiple nations from imposing new taxes, regulations and tariffs on U.S. technology firms and their products ahead of a self-im-

posed Aug. 1 deadline, when higher levies are slated for dozens of nations.

Measures targeting the U.S.’s internet giants remain a sticking point in discussions with Brazil, South Korea and the European Union, according to people familiar with the discussions. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer are scheduled to meet Friday in Washington with South Korea’s trade and finance ministers.

Trump’s abrupt termination of trade talks with Can-

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INSIDE



LARRY BUSACCA/GETTY IMAGES

OBITUARY

Ozzy Osbourne, a pioneer of heavy metal and reality TV, dies at age 76. **A3**

Speaker Halts Session To Avoid Epstein Vote

By JASMINE LI AND SADIE GURMAN

WASHINGTON—House Speaker Mike Johnson cut short this week’s legislative session and sent members home early for their summer break to avoid a vote on releasing files from the investigation of disgraced sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, as some Republican lawmakers demanded.

Leaders said Tuesday the final votes of the week would be Wednesday, and then lawmakers would leave Washington. GOP leaders on Monday canceled House Rules Commit-

tee meetings over concerns Democrats would force votes to release material related to Epstein, who had socialized with President Trump decades ago. Without passing rules, the House can only approve legislation on the floor with a two-thirds majority.

Rep. Ralph Norman (R., S.C.) said leadership was “stalling” on a nonbinding resolution he led to call for disclosures regarding Epstein. “The American people deserve action, not excuses,” he wrote on X. “Let’s vote on it before August recess and get it DONE!!”

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These Crooks Leave a Trail Of Minions

* * *
North Koreans in U.S. firms share ‘Despicable’ fetish

By ROBERT MCMILLAN

American tech companies have a serious problem with a despicable twist.

The FBI believes thousands of North Koreans have infiltrated the U.S. workforce by assuming the identities of Americans to secure remote jobs. Many of them, investigators have found, are bound by a few defining characteristics: total devotion to Dear Leader Kim Jong Un, a penchant for stealing cryptocurrency and an obsession with Minions, the cuddly agents of evil from “Despicable Me.”

The North Koreans’ love of the animated movie franchise *Please turn to page A10*

China Seeks to Break Its Addiction to Oil

Boosts domestic production and EV industry to blunt U.S. pressure point

By BRIAN SPEGELE

BEIJING—China’s thirst for oil drove global demand for decades. Now a government campaign to curb that addiction is nearing a milestone, with national consumption expected to peak by 2027, then begin to fall.

Chinese officials have long worried that the U.S. and its allies could hamstring the nation’s economy by choking off its supply of foreign oil. So China has poured hundreds of billions of dollars into weaning itself off the imported stuff by reviving domestic production and swiftly building the world’s leading electric-vehicle industry.

“The energy rice bowl must be held in our own

hands,” Chinese leader Xi Jinping has said.

Across China, fleets of gas-guzzling Volkswagen and Hyundai taxicabs are being replaced by electric models designed and produced locally. Last year, nearly half of passenger vehicles sold in the country were either all-electrics or plug-in hybrids, compared with 6% in 2020.

In a remote corner of China called the “sea of death” for its harsh conditions, oil workers are trying to coax more crude out of the ground by drilling holes as deep as Mt. Everest is high. State-owned Petro-China reported \$38 billion of capital expenditures last year, nearly as much as Exxon Mobil’s and Chevron’s *Please turn to page A8*

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